

Book 1 of 5 · Armored Fail Fast · a five-book set

Armored Fail Fast

The Pre-Assessment

Take it before you feel ready.

What this is. How to use a practice exam as a diagnosis instead of a score: take it early, think aloud, sort every item by confidence, name the trap, fix the principle, armor it, re-measure.

Book	Title	What it does
1	The Pre-Assessment	Fail fast on the practice exam.
2	The Performance Assessment	Fail fast on your own draft, rubric in hand.
3	The Objective Assessment	Take it, see what happens, and mine the coaching report.
4	The Punch List	Every step of all three, as boxes to check.
5	The Adventure Guide	The breadcrumb trail: what each step gives you, and where the whole path leads.

Domain-free. No institution's course, rubric or assessment content is used or reproduced; examples are invented. Method © 2026 Erik Daniel Lindquist — Guided Mastery · Course Mastery Coach, armored. Drafted with AI assistance under his direction.

Six beliefs

Belief	What it means
Recognition is not mastery	Getting a familiar question right proves you have seen it. The real assessment rewords everything.
Fail early, on purpose	The earliest honest measurement is the cheapest. A miss found on day one costs an hour; the same miss found by the grader costs an attempt.
Confidence is data	Mark sure, unsure or guess on everything. Sure-and-wrong is a wrong mental model — the most dangerous result and the first thing to fix.
Principles, not lookups	Fix the rule that produced the miss, then prove it with a reworded or reversed version. Never re-drill the original wording.
Leverage beats weight	Spend time by weight × your gap × how fast the points come — not by weight alone.
Traps are engineered	Every wrong answer, and every weak paragraph, fails in a predictable way. Name the way and it stops working on you.

The seven traps

Every wrong answer on a test, and every weak paragraph on a submission, fails in one of seven ways. Name it and it stops working.

Mold	On a test item	In written work scored by a rubric
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	A required part of the task is missing or only implied.
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	Restates the prompt or the scenario instead of applying it.
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	Meets a neighbouring aspect, not the one being scored.
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect.	Does a lower verb than asked — describes when told to analyze, recommends without justifying.
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	Unsupported certainty; no limits, risks or conditions stated.
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	Uses the wrong framework, model, source or standard for the job.
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	Length, headings or citations that look like the aspect but do not meet it.

The route

Fail fast: build from the real result — never from topic weight alone.

1. **Take the pre-assessment before you feel ready.** Early is the point. The score is not the product; the list of misses is.
2. **Think aloud, on paper.** For every item write four things: item number · the concept you think it tests · your answer · sure / unsure / guess. Uncoached, no notes.
3. **Pull the report and sort it.** If the report lists the correct answer first, shuffle the options before you look back, or you train position instead of concept.
4. **Triage every item into the four-way grid** (sure/unsure × right/wrong). Sure-and-wrong goes to the top of the plan; unsure-and-right counts as not owned.
5. **Classify each miss:** concept inversion (wrong model — survives rewording), confusion set (right area, wrong entity), or compute slip (knew it, mis-plugged it).
6. **Write an anchor row for every concept tested:** concept · rule · trap · the tell in the question. Read what you selected and work out why before reading any explanation.
7. **Armor it.** Re-ask every concept with more camouflage than the original — extra facts that don't decide it — and give every miss a second, reversed or different-variable item. Run it on paper with the strategy strip filled before the options are read.
8. **Aim by leverage, then re-measure.** Weight × your gap × how fast the points come. Take the next practice or drill cold; update the plan the moment the result contradicts it.

The strategy strip — fill it before you read the options

Target word (what is actually asked)	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
--------------------------------------	---------------------------	--------	-------------------------------

Gap lenses — only with results from more than one attempt

Lens	What it looks like	What to do
Practice → practice (shallow)	Right once, wrong the next time under the same conditions.	Treat as not owned; re-prove from the rule.
Practice → real (transfer failure)	Passed the practice, missed the same idea on the real one.	Usually recognition of reused items — drill disguise, not content.
Real → real (durable)	The same area fails on every real attempt.	Stable and fixable: the model is wrong the same way. Fix it first.

Worksheets

Photocopy. Pencil.

Think-aloud sheet

#	Concept it tests	My answer	Sure / unsure / guess	Right?

Triage grid — write each item number in its box

	Right / competent	Wrong / not competent
Sure	Owned.	Top priority. A wrong model, or evidence you think is there and isn't.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-prove it from the rule.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

Mold	On a pre-assessment item	Your count
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect.	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	